	STANDARD OPERATING PROCEDURE State Form 39870(R/S-06)	Reference Number EWS-002
	Subject Peer Support Program	
	Special Instructions New SOP	Effective Date **December 10, 2025**

I. PURPOSE

Establish guidelines for the Indiana State Police (ISP) Peer Support Program. The program provides trained peer support officers who offer confidential emotional, practical, and moral support to fellow personnel experiencing personal or professional stressors. The team members will provide direction and resources to peer personnel in need of emotional assistance.

II. POLICY

This policy establishes the formation of a peer support structure for all ISP sworn and professional staff personnel, retirees, and families with emotional and tangible support through times of personal or professional crisis and to help anticipate and address any potential difficulties. Experienced and witnessed critical events place a huge toll on the mental health of law enforcement professionals. It is the policy of the Wellness Section to pursue proactive measures in employee health issues. The ISP have a peer support team to provide resources and aid in stress management to department personnel in need. Team members will serve peers across the state through personal observation or at the direction of the Wellness Section Commander or Coordinator.

III. DEFINITIONS

A. CRISIS - A situation that causes emotional distress, such as a critical incident, personal trauma, or professional stress, that may require the support of a peer or from a mental health professional.

B. CONFIDENTIALITY - All communications made in connection with the Peer Support, EAP, Chaplain, or CISM programs are to be treated as confidential, consistent with Indiana law, ISP policy, and ethical standards. Exceptions exist when there is imminent threat to life, safety, or elder, spousal, or child abuse.

C. PEER SUPPORT TEAM - A structured, confidential program where trained ISP personnel provide peer-level emotional and psychological support to coworkers coping with personal or professional challenges. It serves as an early intervention and bridge to professional resources.

D. PEER SUPPORT TEAM MEMBER (PSTM) - A specially trained colleague who provides initial emotional support, not a professional counselor, but one that guides and recommends wellness resources to peers.

E. REFERRAL - The process of connecting an individual with the appropriate outside resources, such as a mental health professional, when their needs exceed the scope of a peer support team member.

F. RISK ASSESSMENT - A process used by peer supporters to identify signs of danger to the individual or others, and to determine the urgency and level of follow-up support that is needed.

G. TRAUMA - A psychological response to a deeply distressing or disturbing event that can have lasting effects on an individual's mental and physical health.

IV. PROCEDURE

A. Utilization of PSTM:

1. The Wellness Section Commander or Coordinator shall notify a PSTM upon the request of an area commander, a district commander, the assistant district commander, supervisor, or a peer when an individual has faced a crisis or trauma.

2. PSTM shall:

a. Continually perform risk assessments of their peers and notify the Wellness Section Commander or Coordinator if they believe that an individual should be offered wellness resources.

(i) A PSTM may recommend available wellness resources to peers; or
(ii) In the event that a risk assessment determines that an individual needs greater intervention, a PSTM shall contact the Wellness Coordinator.

3. PSTMs may be activated and assigned to a peer in crisis, for an individual that has been involved in a serious traumatic event, or one that has been flagged as a "trooper in need."

4. The Area Peer Support Team Leader shall perform routine check-ins with all PSTMs to ensure that individuals are receiving follow-up contacts to determine their well-being and offer additional resources if needed.

B. Selection Process for PSTM

1. When a PSTM vacancy exists, the Wellness Section Commander and Coordinator, with the approval of the Support Services Bureau Commander, shall notify all division, section, zone, area and district commanders of the vacancy, by email, a minimum of five (5) days prior to the closing date.

2. Interested personnel shall submit an application and memo through channels, to the Support Services Bureau Commander.

3. Desirable characteristics for a successful PSTM member are:

a. Demonstrate care and concern for peers;
b. Be empathetic and maintain a non-judgmental attitude;
c. Exhibit trustworthiness and maintain confidentiality;
d. Remain flexible and able to adapt to changing situations and demeanors;
e. Be knowledgeable of all wellness resources;
f. Ability to prioritize the need for self-care awareness to prevent burnout.

4. All applicants must:

a. Must submit an online application and essay
b. Shall undergo a structured selection process including a psychological interview provided by a Department approved psychologist or psychiatrist trained in Critical Incident Stress Management.

5. After completion of the psychological interviews the Wellness Section Commander shall make a recommendation to the Commander of the Support Services Bureau who shall then make the final selection and notify the selected person, in writing, through channels.

C. Training

1. PSTMs shall be properly trained and utilized in accordance with the standards outlined in the Department's Peer Support Team Manual.

D. This procedure is to be used in conjunction with all other relevant Department regulations, rules, policies and procedures